

visual prominence with the Start button on a Vista desktop, makes considerable use of this markup language. Essentially, the Sidebar is a data aggregator that uses XML to gather sundry bits of information, presenting them using vector images and animations.

In terms of functionality, the Sidebar will be a collection of what Microsoft calls Gadgets. The concept of Gadgets is meant to blur across networks, and will function both online (via Start.com) and offline. Some Gadgets will extend online functionality to the desktop and vice-versa. When offline, a Gadget can take the form of a calculator, games, sticky notes, slideshows and such. Online Gadgets can connect to Web services to deliver weather information, news updates, traffic maps, online photo albums (such as from within flickr.com), Internet radio, and more. A Gadget can also integrate with your desktop applications. It can bring you your daily calendar, let you control music or play video, or even offer a window to your Messenger contacts.

They're Live

To underline the user-friendliness of the interface, Vista will offer Live Icons.

Today, you can set XP to show you a thumbnail view of the contents of a folder—or for an image or video file, a snapshot of its content. Vista will extend this concept to all content—a Live Icon for a Word document, for example, will display the content of the first page of the document. The benefits are obvious—"untitled4.doc" will immediately show what it contains, without

The search paradigm has deep roots in Vista. Every user element—from the Start menu to Windows Explorer and the Save dialog boxes—will enable you to search for content

is termed the Windows Collaboration client. This application will let you create a P2P network with up to ten other friends, family members or colleagues. Within such an environment, you can share your desktop with others, exchange data and notes, and collaboratively edit documents. Windows Collaboration will support both wired and wireless networks. If no network is detected, it can even start an ad-hoc network, detecting and connecting to other users via Wi-Fi.

Vista is also set to bring a calendar to the experience sans Outlook. The Windows Calendar will be a rudimentary task manager that will be able to work with Internet-standard calendaring formats. You can use this application to set up a Web-based calendar, or to subscribe to one. The application will be able to notify you of an upcoming event even when it is not running, thanks to deep integration with Vista. The Calendar and Collaboration are two positive steps to blurring physical boundaries while working in this connected age.

Dude, Where's My Data?

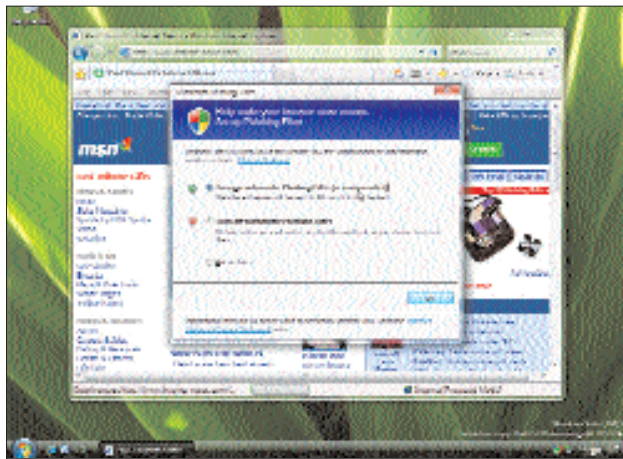
Microsoft toyed with the idea of entirely doing away with the folder/directory/drive letter paradigm that is currently used to store content. They envisioned a single data store that would encompass every file type, and which, with the help of metadata, would be exposed to the user via an almighty search engine. This vision has taken a backseat to practicality—Vista will offer the traditional folder model and marry metadata to it.

Metadata is, of course, bits you can add to a file to render it as unique as possible, thus making it easier to find. Just as an MP3 file can store album, artist, track, and genre information, a Word document can be tagged with author, keywords, and category; a photograph can be tagged with camera information, when it was snapped, and so on. All of this is currently possible, but what Vista offers is a means to best use this wealth of information—via its search and via virtual folders. Of course, you will have to manually enter all this information at some point.

Vista uses the concept of Virtual Folders to leverage the foundation of metadata. A Virtual Folder is just an XML-based search query that automatically and continuously updates its contents based on the search criteria. Thus a search on "jazz music from the 80s" will find every music file with the relevant metadata (genre: jazz, year of release: 1980-1990), which you can then save as Virtual Folder. The contents of this folder would then be updated live, as and when you add or remove relevant content.

This means of storing metadata-rich content will also bring along the concept of stacks. Think of a stack as related data, for example, a stack of books written by Arthur C Clarke. Similarly, Vista will offer a stack of jazz albums, a stack of spreadsheets created in the year 2004, and such. All of this is customisable, of course, and works similar to the way you can ask Windows Explorer under XP today to show all PDFs from the past week.

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Vista's Internet Explorer will offer a phishing filter

your having to open it.

RSS feeds will be deeply integrated with Vista. The OS will maintain a central store of RSS data which you subscribe to—regardless of which RSS reader you use—thus, while Internet Explorer 7 will come with an RSS feed reader, Vista will also store feeds gathered by Firefox, for example. This repository will be available to any application via an API. Vista will also add the concept of lists to RSS feeds—this will allow you to create a feed of, say, the Top 10 Bollywood Albums—something not currently possible.

Along with RSS, another notable technology of our time—peer-to-peer (P2P)—will be integrated with Vista. The most visible form that P2P will take